

TARU: Research Findings, Economics and Recommendation

Survey, 11 interviews, price audit (30 sets) and Google Trends (5 terms, 5 years) ·
30 Sep 2026

Recommendation: pivot, then test. As briefed (four channels including Myntra, full team), TARU loses about ₹73 lakh over 24 months and never breaks even. A leaner plan that drops the marketplace and sells through its own site, festive pop-ups and corporate gifting needs about 280 sets a month to break even, close to the year-2 plan of 250. The festive 2027 pop-up season is the test. Details in sections 9–10.

Research quality. The interviews give usable direction on fit, price and proof. The survey does **not**: after exclusions only 47 responses remain (13–20 per claim card, against 64 needed), and the answers fail four standard quality checks. No survey result below should be used for a decision until a fresh, verified sample is collected. The claim test, Kano and pricing results are shown for transparency, not as evidence.

TARU is a fictional brand created for an independent student portfolio project. Consumer findings come from the author's own research with a convenience sample.

1. Sample and exclusions

Step	Removed	Remaining
Responses received (Forms A, B, C: 60 each)		180
Did not consent	19	161
Under 18	7	154
Screened out (answered “Neither” or left the role question blank)	24	130
Stopped before the claim test	78	52
Failed the attention check	5	47

Analysed: Card A 20, Card B 14, Card C 13. Self-buyers 31, gifters 6, “both” 10. Quotas in the brief (50+ self-buyers, 60+ gifters) are not met. 30 price answers written as text (“too low”, “very high”) were set to missing; city spellings were merged (Bangalore – Bengaluru, and so on).

2. Data-quality checks: four fail

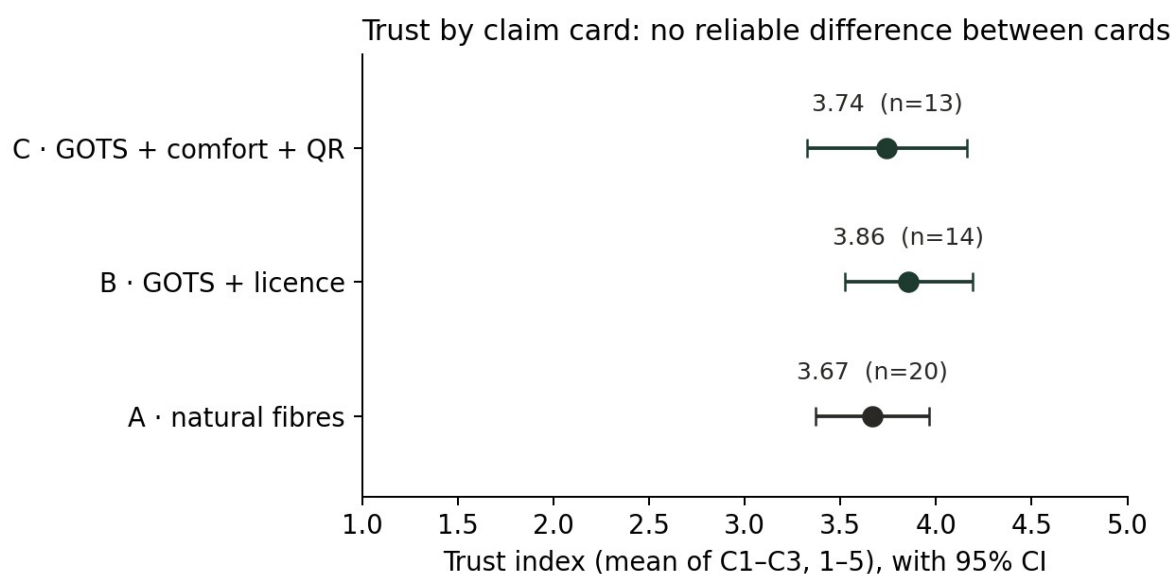
Check	Expected in real survey data	This survey	Verdict
Trust items move together (C1 believe, C2 honest, C3 trust)	Correlation ≈ 0.4 – 0.7 ; Cronbach's $\alpha \geq 0.7$	Correlations -0.15 to 0.02 ; $\alpha = -0.13$	Fail: the three items do not measure one thing
Trust predicts purchase intent (C1–C3 vs C4)	Positive correlation	-0.12 to 0.12	Fail
Purchase likelihood falls as price rises (D5 bargain vs D6 expensive)	Lower at the expensive price	79% said they were <i>more</i> likely to buy at the expensive price (mean 3.8 vs 2.3 on 1–5)	Fail: the reverse of how buyers behave
Price answers in order (too cheap $\leq$ bargain $\leq$ expensive $\leq$ too expensive)	Under 10–15% violations	19 of 47 (40%) everyday; 15 of 47 (32%) ceremonial	Fail
Kano answers logically possible	Reverse + questionable under $\sim 5\%$	5–23% per feature	Borderline to fail

A pattern where items that should agree are unrelated, and price responses run backwards, is what answers look like when they are chosen independently at random. It can also come from a form error (for example, a scale printed in reverse) or from respondents clicking through. **Before this data is used anywhere, find the cause:** check the live form's question order and scale labels against the export, and check how the three Sheets were combined.

3. Survey results (not decision-grade)

3.1 Claim test

Card	n	Trust (1-5)	Would buy (top 2)	Would pay $\geq 10\%$ over Manyavar
A · natural fibres	20	3.67	55%	55%
B · GOTS + licence	14	3.86	79%	29%
C · GOTS + comfort + QR	13	3.74	77%	38%



Trust by claim card

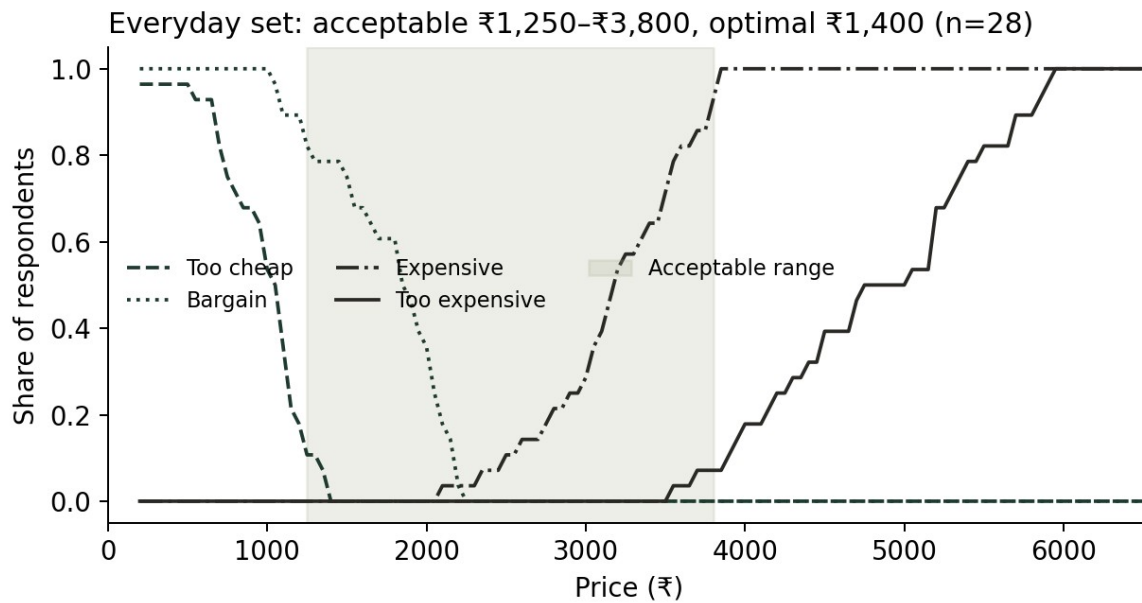
Kruskal-Wallis $p = 0.71$. Effect sizes (Cohen's d , bootstrap 95% CI): B vs A 0.29 [−0.37, 1.03]; C vs B −0.16 [−1.02, 0.59]; C vs A 0.11 [−0.64, 0.85]. Every interval spans zero and is too wide to rule in or out even a large effect. With $\alpha = -0.13$ the trust index itself is not valid, so **H2 is untested**, not rejected.

3.2 Kano

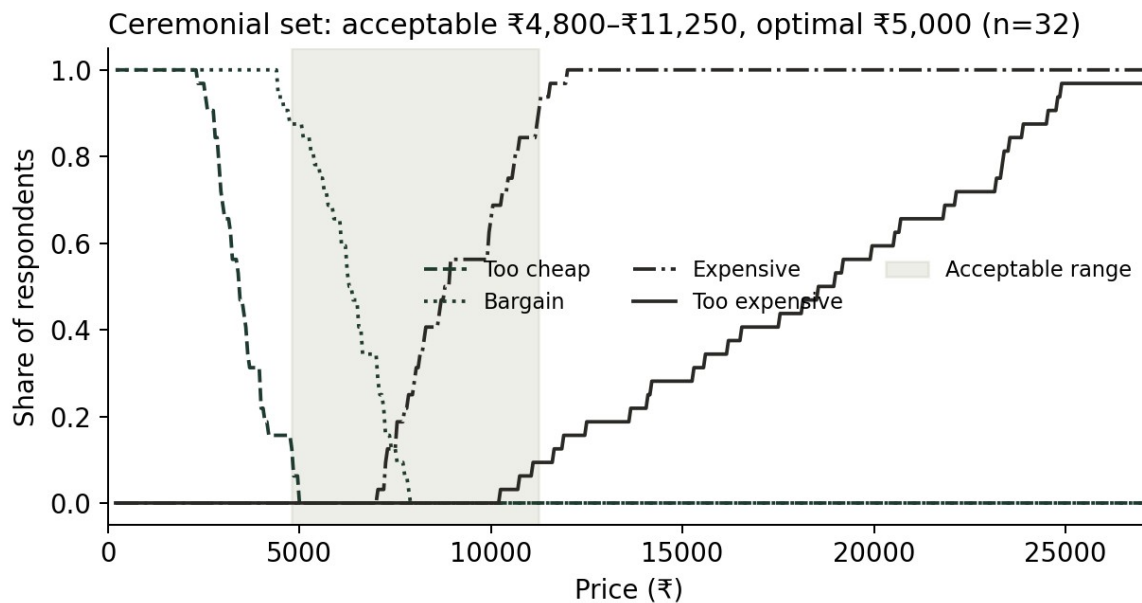
All six features classify as *Indifferent*: certified organic, QR trail, fuller-build cut, free alterations, comfort guarantee and styling help. Better/worse coefficients are 0.27–0.38 / −0.17 to −0.33. Given the quality checks, this more likely reflects noise than genuine indifference.

3.3 Van Westendorp (order-consistent answers only)

	n	Acceptable range	Optimal price	Indifference price
Everyday set	28	₹1,250–₹3,800	₹1,400	₹2,200
Ceremonial set	32	₹4,800–₹11,250	₹5,000	₹7,400



Everyday set price curves



Ceremonial set price curves

These ranges agree with the interviews (everyday ₹1,200–2,500; wedding ₹3,500–8,000), which is the one place the survey and the interviews line up. The NMS revenue curve is not computed because the purchase-likelihood answers run backwards (section 2).

3.4 Brand look, channel and payment

- **Look preference:** Look 2 (Quiet Proof) 46% [95% CI 32–60%], Look 1 (Heritage) 35% [23–49%], Look 3 (Occasion) 20% [11–33%]. Looks 1 and 2 overlap; no clear winner.
- **Where they'd buy (46 answered, multi-select):** marketplace app 16, brand website 15, through a tailor 14, brand store 13, corporate or festive gift 11, multi-brand store 11, pop-up 6.
- **Pay on delivery: 64%.** Online comfort averages 3.1 of 5. If this holds in clean data, D2C return-to-origin risk is high (see register R062–R064).

4. Interviews (11)

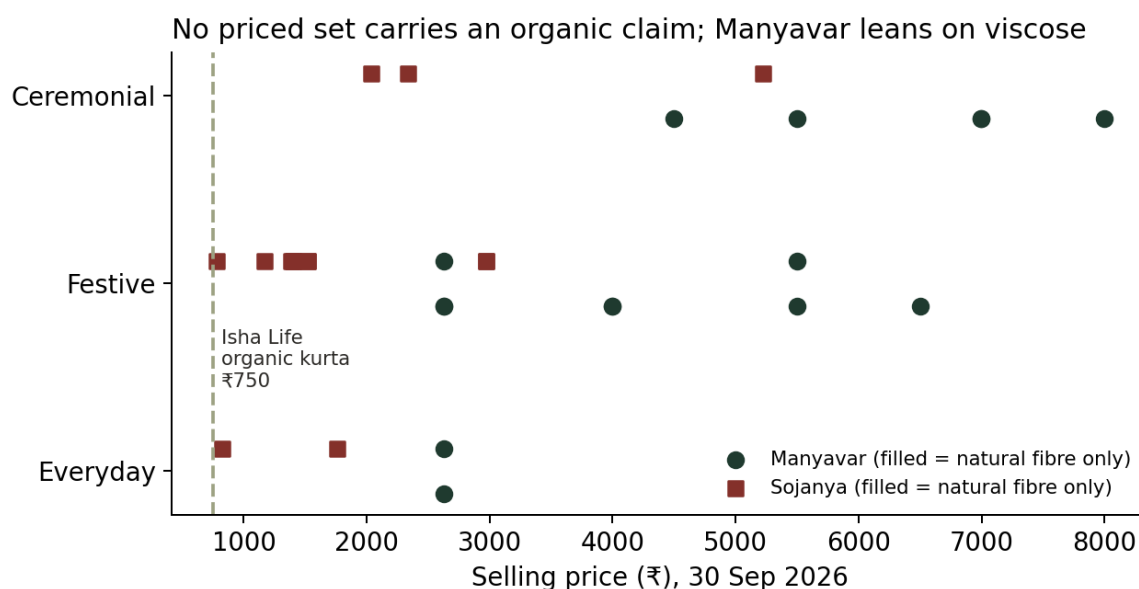
Coding in research/interviews/interview_coding.csv.

Theme	Evidence	Count
Standard sizes fail mature builds	Belly, chest, armholes, neck or sleeves named as a problem	8 of 9 buyers + both practitioners
Proof: certification tag leads, narrowly	First choice: P1 tag 4, P2 QR trail 3, P3 comfort guarantee 2 (buyers); both practitioners chose P1	4 / 3 / 2
“Organic” means the wearer’s skin before the planet	Skin or health 4, planet or ethics 3, purity or tradition 2	4 / 3 / 2
Touch before purchase	Prefer store or boutique for hand-feel: 5 of 9; open to online with easy returns: 4 of 9	5 / 4
Everyday price	Self-buyers: ₹1,200–2,500 (median ₹2,000)	5
Gift budget	₹2,000–10,000, with packaging expected as standard	4

What interviews did not deliver. Neither practitioner gave margin, sale-or-return or payment-term ranges, the main purpose of those interviews (R069 stays an assumption). The “surprises” field cites hypotheses by the wrong number in two notes (online channels are H5, not H3). The notes are Claude-cleaned summaries of recordings; keep the original recordings privately so any quote can be checked against source.

5. Price audit (30 products, read from brand pages on 29–30 Sep 2026)

Brand	Sets priced	Median selling price	Range	Average discount off MRP	Natural fibre only
Manyavar	15	₹4,499	₹2,624–7,999	0%	3 of 15
Sojanya	14	₹1,517	₹777–5,226	68%	14 of 14
Isha Life (organic kurta only, anchor)	1	₹750		0%	yes



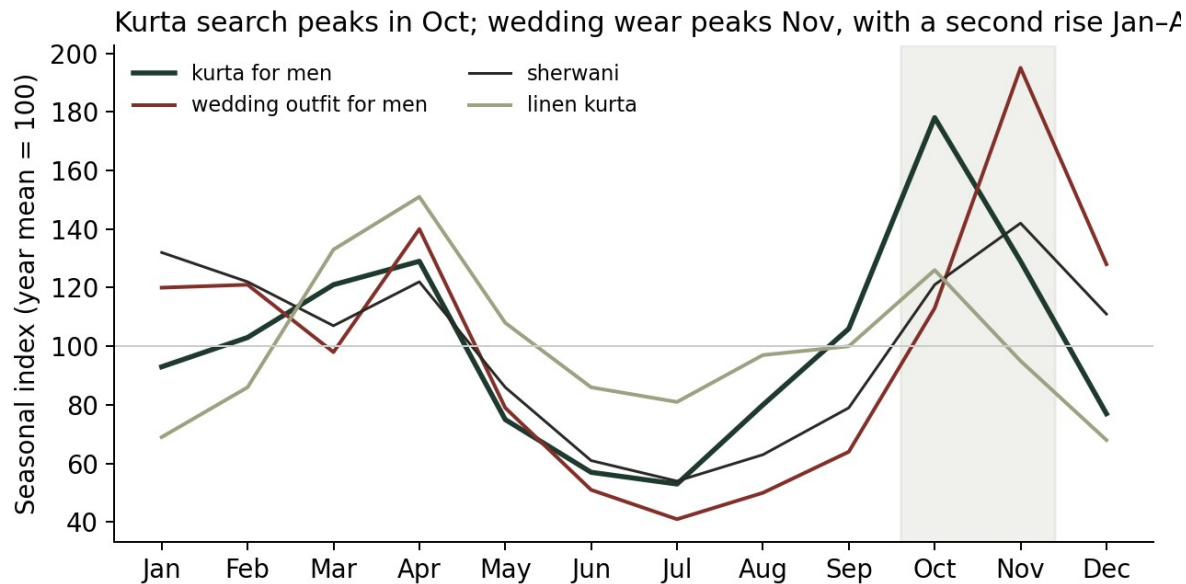
Price audit

- **None of the 29 sets makes any organic or certification claim.** The white space for certified-organic occasion wear holds.
- **The market leader sells mostly viscose.** 12 of 15 Manyavar sets are viscose, georgette, art silk or brocade. A certified natural-fibre set is a real point of difference against Manyavar, not only against discounters.
- **Manyavar never discounts; Sojanya lists at an MRP it almost never charges** (68% off on average). TARU's "no markdowns on Ceremonial" rule matches the leader, not the discounter.
- **The everyday premium is tight.** Manyavar's natural-fibre everyday set sells at ₹2,624; 10% above that is about ₹2,900. Interviewees expect ₹1,200–2,500 for everyday, and the survey's indifference price is ₹2,200. A 10% premium looks achievable on festive and ceremonial sets (Manyavar ceremonial median about ₹6,000, survey acceptable range up to ₹11,250), not on everyday.
- **Gap:** Tasva (16 sets) and Fabindia (2) pages need a browser to show prices, so they are not priced. Brief target was 40+ sets from 6+ brands; this audit has 30 from 3.

6. Demand seasonality and geography (Google Trends, India, Sep 2021–Sep 2026)

Seasonal index, 2022–2025 average (each year's mean = 100):

Term	Peak months	Trough	Five-year trend (annual mean, 2021 – 2026)
kurta for men	Oct (178) , Apr, Nov	Jun–Jul	26 – 31, broadly flat
wedding outfit for men	Nov (195) , Apr, Dec	Jul–Aug	21 – 43, doubled
sherwani	Nov (142), Jan, Feb	Jun–Jul	79 – 44, falling
linen kurta	Apr (151), Mar, Oct	Dec–Jan	17 – 61, more than tripled
organic cotton	Nov, Feb (flat otherwise)		9 – 21; the 2026 rise is mostly a one-week spike in Feb 2026



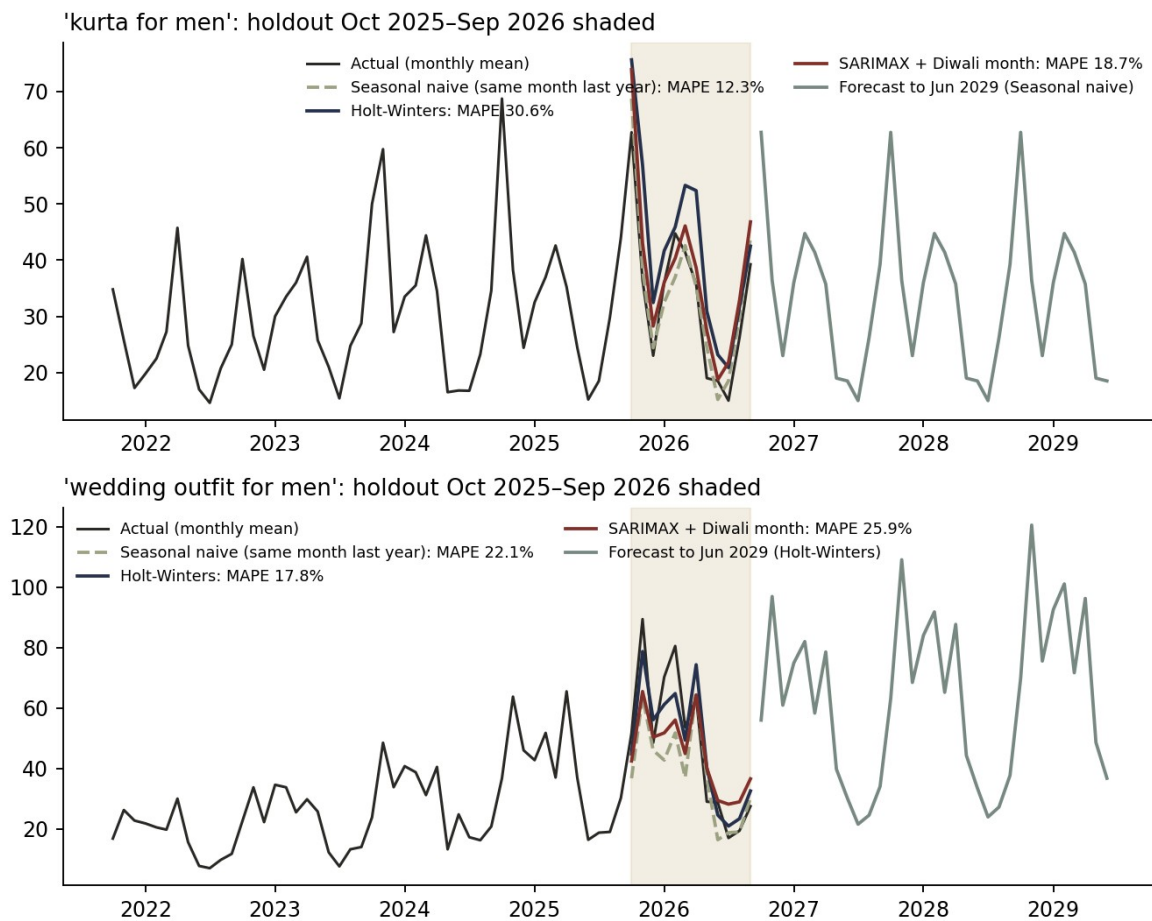
Seasonality

- **Demand peaks Oct–Nov** (Diwali, then wedding season), with a second, smaller rise Jan–Apr (weddings, then summer linen). Stock for the peak must land by September, so the cash low point falls in Aug–Sep. **H6 is supported.**
- **Linen is the fastest-growing search** and peaks in the summer months, when ethnic demand otherwise falls. An everyday linen line would smooth the calendar.
- **Geography:** Delhi and Maharashtra rank top-2 on almost every term; Karnataka is strong on linen and organic cotton. This supports Delhi NCR, Mumbai, Pune and Bengaluru as launch cities. Tamil Nadu and Goa search most for “organic cotton” but little for kurtas, so they are not launch markets.
- Trends show relative search interest, not sales; treat them as timing evidence only.

6.1 AI7: demand forecast

Three methods were trained on Oct 2021 – Sep 2025 and tested on the 12 months they had not seen (Oct 2025 – Sep 2026). Error is mean absolute percentage error (MAPE); lower is better.

Method	“kurta for men”	“wedding outfit for men”
Same month last year (baseline)	12.3%	22.1%
Holt-Winters exponential smoothing	30.6%	17.8%
SARIMAX with a Diwali-month regressor	18.7%	25.9%

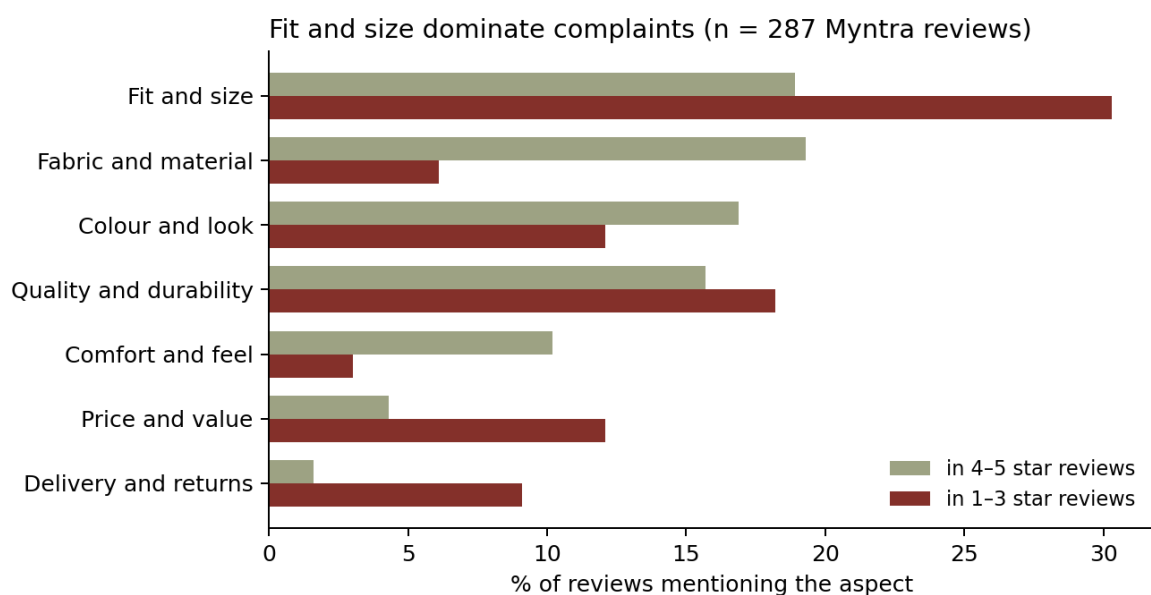


Demand forecast

- **For everyday kurta demand, the simple baseline wins.** The season repeats so closely that the models add error, mostly by over-reacting to the Diwali date moving between October and November. A model is kept only if it beats the baseline; here it does not.
- **For wedding wear, Holt-Winters wins** because it picks up the upward trend (searches doubled since 2021). Its long-range forecast assumes that growth continues, so treat 2028–29 levels as optimistic.
- **Both forecasts peak in October–November in 2027 and 2028**, confirming the timing used in the cash plan (stock paid by September). Monthly weights for Jul 2027 – Jun 2029 are in `data/clean/ai7_forecast_results.json`.
- Code: `notebooks/10_demand_forecast.py`. Google Trends measures search interest, not sales.

6.2 AI2: review complaint map (287 Myntra reviews)

Reviews were copied by hand from Myntra on 30 Sep 2026: Fabindia 199, Manyavar 85, Tasva 3 after removing 5 blank and 4 duplicate rows. Reviewer names were dropped on load. 33 reviews are rated 1–3 stars. Each review is tagged against a published keyword list (`notebooks/02_review_complaint_map.py`); an NMF topic model on TF-IDF features is run alongside as an unsupervised check.



Complaint map

Aspect	Share of all reviews	In 1–3 star reviews	In 4–5 star reviews
Fit and size	20%	30%	19%
Fabric and material	18%	6%	19%
Colour and look	16%	12%	17%
Quality and durability	16%	18%	16%
Comfort and feel	9%	3%	10%
Price and value	5%	12%	4%
Delivery and returns	2%	9%	2%

- **Fit and size is the top complaint.** It appears in 30% of low-rated reviews against 19% of high-rated ones. Size complaints run both ways (“too big, especially sleeves”, “little tight”, “length is too long”). The topic model finds the same thing: its size topic has the lowest average rating of the five topics (3.6 stars).
- **Fabric and comfort are what people praise.** They appear three times more often in good reviews than in bad ones. For a natural-fibre brand, fabric is expected; the gap a new brand can own is fit.
- **Price and delivery are mentioned rarely, but mostly in complaints.**
- **4% of reviews say the kurta was bought for someone else** (father, husband, brother, teacher), a small but visible gifting signal.
- This agrees with the interviews, where 8 of 9 buyers named a fit problem.

Limits. 287 reviews against a target of 400; Tasva is almost absent; only 1 review is in Hinglish, so AI1’s English-vs-Hinglish comparison cannot be run. Reviews skew positive (89% rated 4–5), as marketplace reviews usually do.

7. Status of the hypotheses

	Hypothesis	Status	Why
H1	Self-buyer is the stronger first customer	Untested	6 gifters analysed; quality checks fail
H2	Certification raises trust; benefit + QR raises it further	Untested	Arms 13–20 (need 64); trust scale invalid
H3	Market big enough	Not a survey question	Sizing v1 stands; search growth for wedding wear and linen supports it

	Hypothesis	Status	Why
H4	≥ 10% premium over Manyavar, ≥ 50% margin	Rejected on margin; premium feasible only for festive and ceremonial	Everyday: 10% over Manyavar (~₹2,900) sits above interview and survey expectations (~₹2,000–2,200). Festive and ceremonial: room for a premium. Margin untested until the cost stack
H5	D2C and marketplace both positive; a low-cost channel beats modern trade	Partly rejected	D2C positive; marketplace negative on every line; pop-ups earn most per set
H6	Peak Oct–Dec; cash low 1–2 months before	Supported	Kurta peaks Oct, wedding wear Nov

8. Economics (model/taru_economics.xlsx)

Base case: 1,800 sets in year 1 and 3,000 in year 2 (sizing v1), sold July 2027 – June 2029 on the Google Trends season.

Line	Price	GST	Cost per set (COGS)	Gross margin	Clears the 50% floor?
Everyday	₹2,499	5%	₹1,507	37%	No
Festive	₹4,999	18%	₹2,700	36%	No
Ceremonial (with jacket)	₹8,999	18%	₹5,528	28%	No

Fabric cost uses IndiaMART GOTS organic cotton listings (₹110–350 per metre) and stitching job-work rates (₹300–700 per set); trims, packaging and certification are assumptions. **No line reaches H4's 50% gross-margin floor;** Manyavar's is 65.7% on mostly viscose fabric. Certified natural fibre costs more, and the price ceiling people accept leaves little room.

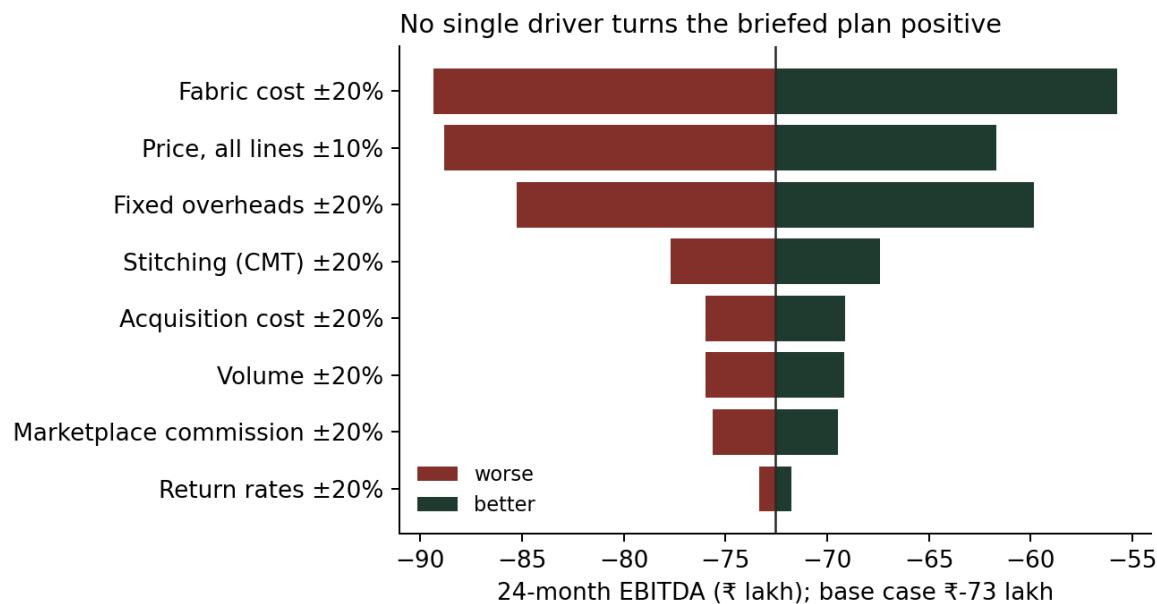
Contribution per set, after channel costs and acquisition:

Channel	Everyday	Festive	Ceremonial
Own website (D2C)	₹117	₹699	₹1,114
Marketplace (Myntra, 27.5% commission)	–₹151	–₹44	–₹499
Pop-up	₹360	₹974	₹1,446
Corporate gifting (15% off)	₹282	₹664	₹711

The marketplace loses money on every line at a press-estimated 27.5% commission (register R069, low confidence). Pop-ups earn the most per set because there is no shipping or return cost. Blended across the plan, each set contributes ₹355 (9%).

Result (base case)	As briefed	Pivot plan
Contribution per set	₹355	₹677
Sets per month needed to break even	~957	~281
24-month EBITDA	–₹72.6 lakh	–₹18.1 lakh
Peak funding need (lowest cumulative cash)	₹77.6 lakh	₹27.5 lakh

Pivot plan = no marketplace (own website 40%, pop-ups 30%, corporate gifting 30%); overheads ₹1.5 lakh a month; brand content ₹40,000 a month; launch spend ₹5 lakh; everyday fabric at ₹140/m.



Sensitivity

Fabric cost, fixed overheads and price move the 24-month result most. No single $\pm 20\%$ change turns the brief's plan positive, which is why the pivot changes channels and overheads together.

9. Recommendation: pivot, then test

1. **Do not launch as briefed.** Four channels with a marketplace and a full team cannot break even at prices buyers accept for certified natural fibre.
2. **Pivot the launch** to festive and wedding occasion wear sold through pop-ups, corporate festive gifting and the brand's own site. Keep everyday as a small entry line priced under the ₹2,500 GST slab; it is a door-opener, not a margin line.
3. **Lead the message with fit and comfort, with certification as proof.** Interviews put fit first (8 of 9 buyers), fit is the top complaint in competitor reviews, and buyers read "organic" as skin comfort; the survey cannot yet confirm the claim test.
4. **Test before scaling:** run 3–4 pop-ups in Oct–Nov 2027 (the Trends peak). Go on if they sell at least ~280 sets a month at full price with under 5% returns. If not, stop, or move to a supplier-brand or corporate-gifting-only model.
5. **Conditions that would change this call:** a GOTS fabric source under ₹140/m for festive linen; a marketplace commission under 15%; a clean survey showing a significant trust lift for certification (Card B vs A).

10. What would make the survey decision-grade

1. Find the cause of the failed checks (section 2) before collecting more.
2. Target **64+ usable responses per card** (about 200 usable in total). At this survey's completion rate (47 of 130 qualified), that needs about 550 qualified starts, so shorten the form: the drop-off happened before the claim test.
3. Recruit more gifters: 6 is too few to compare segments.
4. Keep this dataset as a documented pilot in the repo, not as the result.